THE MATHEMATICS OF THE GREAT TITHE

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The primary difficulty with possessing four arms, Skrix had long concluded, was that it gave the universe four distinct opportunities to make you drop something valuable.

Floating in the zero-gravity cargo hold of the *Rust-Weevil*, Skrix used his two upper hands to cling stubbornly to an overhead structural pipe while his two lower hands wrestled with a rusty iron pry-bar. His multifaceted compound eyes, each made of three thousand iridescent hexagonal lenses, twitched with focused irritation as he attempted to unjam the lid of a dented steel crate. Around him, the air smelled of scorched insulation, old sweat, and the sharp, sour tang of cheap hydrazine thruster exhaust—the universal scent of Scavenger domesticity.

"Mind the seal, Skrix," muttered Krikk, who was suspended upside-down three feet away, his magnetic boot-clamps locked onto the ribbed steel deck-plate. Krikk was young, had an unbroken glossy sheen to his dark-brown chitin, and still possessed that tragic, starry-eyed optimism common to third-tier raiders who had not yet been shot in the thorax. "The Raiding Captain said if we dent the casing, he's deducting two marks of ration chits from our tally."

"The Raiding Captain," Skrix rasped, his lower mandibles clicking together in a dry, rhythmic clatter that sounded like two dry sticks being snapped in an empty tin, "can take his *krskva* ration chits and shove them straight up his *skvskrsk*. Sideways, if he prefers. Without grease, if he insists on this being finished before the third shift."

With a screech of protesting iron, the crate lid popped free, drifting lazily into the center of the hold.

Inside, cushioned in layers of scorched thermal insulation, lay the true prize of their lightning raid on a frontier research dig along the Wanabo border: an intact Precursor catalytic core. To the ivory-tower physicists at the Sphere Research Center, it was a priceless impossibility—a brick-sized slab of seamless black glass whose non-baryonic lattice resonated with the diffuse dark matter halo of the Sphere, silently transmuting invisible cosmic mass into a steady, boundless flow of direct electrical current. To Skrix and Krikk, it was something far simpler and infinitely more sacred: a battery that never ran dry. You could clamp copper leads to either pole of the cold glass, bolt it into the belly of an asteroid scow, and run life-support scrubbers, target radars, and railgun capacitor banks for two centuries without burning a single droplet of precious helium-3 fuel. Right now, it pulsed with a slow, dull violet rhythm that made the magnetic clamps on Skrix's boots tingle—pulled straight from a freshly unearthed Vault trench before the Sphere Research Center could slap their quarantine beacons on it.

And stuffed around the edges—crammed into the empty corners by two greedy grunts while the perimeter sirens were still wailing—lay the common salvage they had snatched for personal keeping: seven copper water-pipe elbows, a cracked diagnostic slate, a spool of braided wire, and four dented cans of preserved Landfall peaches in heavy syrup.

Krikk's antennae stood straight up in predatory excitement. His upper claws reached reverently toward the black glass, but his lower claws drifted immediately toward the food.

"Look at that catalytic core, Skrix! Pure Vault stock! The Collector himself will sing through the comms when the Chief slides that down the chute! And real fruit! Skrix, by the holy chitin of the Maker, between the relic bounty and the scrap, we're going to buy ourselves onto the second deck! I'm taking one of the peach tins. I've never tasted fruit that didn't come out of a nutrient paste injector."

Skrix sighed—a wet, rattling hiss that escaped through six thoracic spiracles along his ribcage. He reached down with his lower-left claw, plucked the boy's reaching hand out of the air, and shoved him back toward his tether.

"You are not taking the peaches, Krikk. You are not taking the wire. The core belongs to the Chief the second we clear the airlock, and if you are exceptionally lucky with the rest, you might be allowed to keep three shavings of copper dust to scrape between your molars for flavor."

"That's against the rules!" Krikk protested, his four hands waving in symmetrical indignation. "We were the breach-runners! We bled for this salvage! The rules say raiders get fifty percent of whatever personal pickings they haul out!"

"The rules," Skrix said patiently, wrapping a frayed webbing strap around the copper pipes so they wouldn't float into the ventilation grille, "were written by someone who had four arms, six eyes, and an immense ledger, and who was standing behind a reinforced blast bulkhead twelve decks above your head. Allow me to explain the holy mathematics of the Great Tithe, as revealed to our ancestors by the Collector himself."

Skrix held up the four cans of peaches, two in each upper hand, like a priest demonstrating the mysteries of the cosmos to an especially dim-witted acolyte.

"There are four cans," Skrix began. "A clean, harmonious number. You and I bled for them. Therefore, we present them to Raiding Captain Vorash alongside the Vault relic. Captain Vorash looks at the four cans and immediately discovers that the holy cause requires two of them. One for ship's maintenance—because hydrazine doesn't grow on space rocks—and one as the Captain's Discretionary Tithe, which he will eat while watching us scrub the bilge on the bridge camera. That leaves two cans."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "One for you, one for me."

"Do not gallop ahead of the theology," Skrix snapped, tapping Krikk on the head with the flat of the pry-bar. "Captain Vorash does not own this bucket of rust. The *Rust-Weevil* belongs to Clan Vrag-Kresh. When we dock at the Outward Spire of the Hoard, Clan Chief Gresh-Mor will board the vessel with eight enforcers wearing powered carapaces. The Chief will take the Precursor core—naturally—and then he will inspect our remaining two cans. He will explain that Clan Vrag-Kresh is currently in an expensive trade dispute with the Iron Fang cartel over salvage rights to a derelict ore barge, and therefore the Clan requires a mandatory fifty percent sovereignty tax on all personal scrap. There goes the third can."

Krikk's antennae drooped, folding flat against the crown of his carapace. "Leaving... one can."

"Leaving one can," Skrix agreed somberly. "And then, young Krikk, comes the majesty of creation itself. Our great, sprawling, glorious junk-world: the Hoard. A moon made entirely of four centuries of stolen titanium, twisted bulkheads, dormant Precursor coils, and crushed dreams, all orbiting the outer dark like a massive, metallic tumor. At the center of the Hoard sits the Collector."

Skrix paused, bowing his head slightly and making the ceremonial four-fingered sign of the Clasped Fist over his primary heart.

"Our father. A veritable God of Greed. An immortal cosmic intelligence capable of calculating the trajectory of every photon in the cluster, who uses that unfathomable intellect to catalog every bent nail and canned peaches we bring them. When Clan Chief Gresh-Mor approaches the Golden Chute to present the Clan's monthly tribute, the Collector's automated collection maw will descend from the vaulted ceiling. The Collector will receive the catalytic core with divine satisfaction, look down upon the final can of peaches, register its barcode, determine that canned sugar is a rare and unique cultural complexity not currently cataloged in the Archives, and suck it into the celestial vaults forever. In return, he will radiate a warm, benevolent wave of cosmic static that bestows a five-percent reduction on our Clan's annual reproductive licensing fee."

Krikk stared at the empty space between Skrix's hands, his multifaceted eyes dimming in profound, bureaucratic despair. "So... what do we get?"

"We get the lid," Skrix said brightly, handing him the jagged circle of stamped tin. "If you lick the rim very carefully, you can sometimes detect the phantom molecular ghost of high-fructose corn syrup without severing your tongue. It builds character. It makes you lean and hungry for the next raid."

Krikk drifted backward into his safety webbing, curling all four limbs inward until he looked like an oversized, disgruntled walnut. "The Sphere is a miserable place, Skrix. Everything out there wants to kill us, and everything in here wants to charge us for the privilege."

"Of course it is," Skrix said, securing the cargo straps with brisk, practiced yanks. "Survival is purely an exercise in knowing which particular horror is currently attempting to turn your thorax inside out, and running in the opposite direction with your loot tucked securely under your second pair of arms."

"What's the worst one?" Krikk asked quietly, peering out through the small, thick quartz viewport at the cold, star-dusted blackness of the frontier void. "The Orks?"

"The Orks are loud, but they are honest," Skrix muttered, pulling a greasy rag from his utility pouch to polish the grit from his leg joints. "An Ork doesn't bother with subtlety. Their entire design philosophy is taking a heavy naval hull, strapping four times as much reactor thrust to the back as the frame was built to handle, and bolting the biggest, ugliest cannons they can forge to the front. You run into an Orkish gunboat in the Wanabo buffer, and what happens? They don't hail you. They don't threaten to board. They just roll out heavy broadside macro-cannons the size of factory smokestacks and fire eight-hundred-millimeter high-explosive shells until the space around you is mostly shrapnel and expanding fire. If an Ork hits you, you don't need a medical kit, Krikk; you need an envelope so your clan can mail your ashes home. But an Orkish ship is the size of an apartment block and burns hot enough to light up the passive sensors three sectors away. You see his drive flare coming from half an astronomical unit out, and you run."

"And the Flotilla?"

Skrix shuddered, his carapace plates shivering against one another with a dry, papery rustle. "The Flotilla isn't scary until you look at the sensor board. With an Ork, you can hear him screaming through the bulkhead. With the Flotilla, you're drifting through an orbital lane three light-seconds out, thinking you're completely alone, and suddenly your console pings with a prerecorded, agonizingly polite radio chime. A calm, bored voice informs you that under Section 123, Sub-clause XYZ of the whatever mumbo jumbo, your unregistered transponder has violated sovereign orbital clearance. And while the voice is still reading the second paragraph of the legal citation, an eight-hundred-meter capital frigate three thousand kilometers away fires a two-ton solid tungsten dart from an electromagnetic spinal railgun. You don't even see the ship. You just see a flash of relativistic light, and suddenly your engine block is a cloud of hot copper vapor. They don't even raise their voices, Krikk. It's just clerks with three-mile kinetic lances."

"What about the tall ones on X'ara?" Krikk asked, his voice hushed. "The Ancestrals?"

"Worse," Skrix hissed. "They don't even have the decency to use radios. You land on an Ancestral moon by mistake to pick through an ancient spire, and they don't shout, they don't shoot slug-throwers, they don't even breathe. They just step out of the shadows in those shimmering, bone-white silks, gliding across the floor without touching the dust. You point your rifle at them, you pull the trigger, and the slug just stops in mid-air, drops to the floorboards, and then a singing spear made of hard light slides through your primary breastplate before you can finish blinking all your eye-facets. And they look at you while you die—not with hatred, mind you. Hatred would be flattering. They look at you the way a fastidious housekeeper looks at an oily smudge on an antique crystal goblet."

"And the dragons?"

"The dragons?" Skrix shuddered violently, all four of his claws locking tight around his pry-bar. "Do not even speak of the dragons, Krikk. Those are not beasts. They are giant, hungry nightmares living out in the black. You see a shadow in the dark that blots out the stars, and then two eyes open that burn like suns. They chew through ten inches of hull plating like dried kelp just to drink the fuel from your engines. When a dragon finds you, there is no fight, no boarding, and no escape—just a flash of fire, your ship crushed like an eggshell, and you're gone. But even a dragon is huge. You see the heat on your screens from millions of miles off. You keep your lights off, you drift cold, and you pray to the Collector it finds someone else to eat."

Krikk uncurled slightly, scratching at his mandible. "So what is it, then? If you can run from an Ork gunboat, avoid a Flotilla frigate, and drift cold past a dragon... what is the worst thing in the Sphere?"

Skrix lowered his tools. His four hands settled flat against his chitinous knees. When he spoke, his voice was barely a dry scrape of wind through his spiracles.

"Corsairs."

Krikk blinked his upper four eyes, then his lower two. "Corsairs? The Chief said they're just small-time scavengers. A few people in a little boat."

"The Chief," Skrix said with venomous precision, "is an old fat tick who hasn't left his cushioned couch in twenty years, and the only exercise he gets is chewing synthetic kelp and counting his share of our misery. Listen to me, boy. The Orks, the Flotilla, the dragons—what do they all have in common? They are big. They are loud. You can see them coming. An Ork gunboat spits fire across half the sky. A Flotilla warship lights up the void like a lantern. Even a wild dragon burns hot enough to blind your sensors. If you keep your eyes open, you can see them from millions of miles away. You cut your engines, tuck behind an asteroid, hold your breath, and let them pass."

Skrix leaned in close, his antennae twitching against Krikk's forehead.

"You don't see a Corsair coming, Krikk. That's what makes them terrifying."

"Why? Are their ships fast?"

"Their ships look like *nothing*," Skrix whispered. "They don't fly battleships. They fly a tiny little boat no bigger than a cargo hopper. No giant guns. No big glowing engines. They run cold and quiet through the dark. You glance at your sensor screen, you think it's a drifting rock or an empty piece of scrap. You don't run, because you don't even know you're being hunted. And then—their clamps hit your hull."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "And then?"

"And then three people climb through your hatch. Maybe four. Not an army. Just three or four small creatures in plain, scuffed suits."

"Just three?" Krikk asked, his antennae tilting with skepticism. "Against a whole raiding crew?"

"That's the trap, boy. You look at them and think, *'There's only three of them. We have claws, we have guns, we can kill them.'* And before you even raise your weapon, you're already on the deck."

"How?"

"Because they don't yell. They don't posture. They just move. Fast. Faster than you can think. One of them grabs your barrel, snaps your wrist like a dry twig, and pins you to the wall with one hand. Another one slips right past you, clears the whole corridor in four seconds, and puts a dart into the Captain before he even gets out of his chair. They don't look like monsters, Krikk. They look like tired people doing a chore. And by the time your brain figures out that you're under attack, your arms are zip-tied behind your back, your loot is in their bag, and they're walking back to their ship complaining about the draft."

Krikk swallowed hard, his throat clicking. "Have you... seen that happen?"

"Three years ago," Skrix whispered, shivering until his carapace plates rattled against his ribcage. "On an abandoned fuel station. Our raiding team was stripping copper conduits when their cutter docked. No warning sirens, no drive flare. Just a quiet hiss, and suddenly three of them were in the corridor."

"What did you do?" Krikk asked wide-eyed. "Did you fight them?"

"Fight them?" Skrix looked at the boy like he had suggested chewing on a live plasma torch. "I fell face-first into a puddle of cold machine oil, curled all four of my arms tight against my belly, tucked my antennae under my collar, and played dead. I played so dead I stopped my secondary heart from beating."

"Did it work?"

"One of them walked right past me," Skrix said, his voice dropping to a trembling rasp. "Tapped my shell with the toe of a scuffed boot. Said to the other one: *'Don't bother with that one, it's already popped.'* I lay in that puddle of freezing oil for four hours without blinking an eye-facet, Krikk. Four hours. I didn't dare breathe until their thruster wake was two light-minutes out."

Krikk looked around the dimly lit cargo hold, suddenly finding the cold shadows between the storage lockers far more threatening than he had two minutes ago. "Well... at least we're four days out from the Wanabo frontier line. Nothing can track a dead-burn ballistic vector through the outer asteroid belt without active radar, and if anyone lit up active radar, our passive sensors would—"

A sharp, shrill electronic ping chimed across the sensor console.

Skrix froze. All four of his hands remained locked in place, suspended in mid-air.

Then came the urgent, double-pulsed chime of an emergency proximity alarm.

From the cockpit three compartments forward, a muffled, panicked scream tore through the intercom, followed immediately by the frantic clicking of Raiding Captain Vorash's terrified mandibles:

"All hands! All hands to breach stations! We've got an un-identified contact on our dorsal blind spot! No drive plume! No transponder! They were riding our exhaust shadow!"

Before Krikk could even reach for his slug-thrower, the entire five-hundred-ton hull of the *Rust-Weevil* groaned with a sickening shudder, like an iron anvil dropped onto an empty steel drum.

It wasn't the violent, tearing collision of an Orkish cannon shell. It was the heavy, precision bite of pneumatic magnetic harpoons—four heavy steel tethers punching through the outer micrometeorite shielding and locking onto the structural keel with hydraulic finality.

Directly above their heads, on the exterior surface of the cargo bay's primary airlock hatch, came the heavy, rhythmic vibration of magnetic boots pacing across the hull.

Then, through the heavy steel hatch, came a sound that made Skrix's compound eyes dilate in absolute, paralyzing horror.

It was the high-frequency, pressurized hiss of a thermal cutting torch, tracing a neat, rectangular line through the exterior blast seal.

Skrix looked at Krikk. "So, the trick to playing dead is this..."